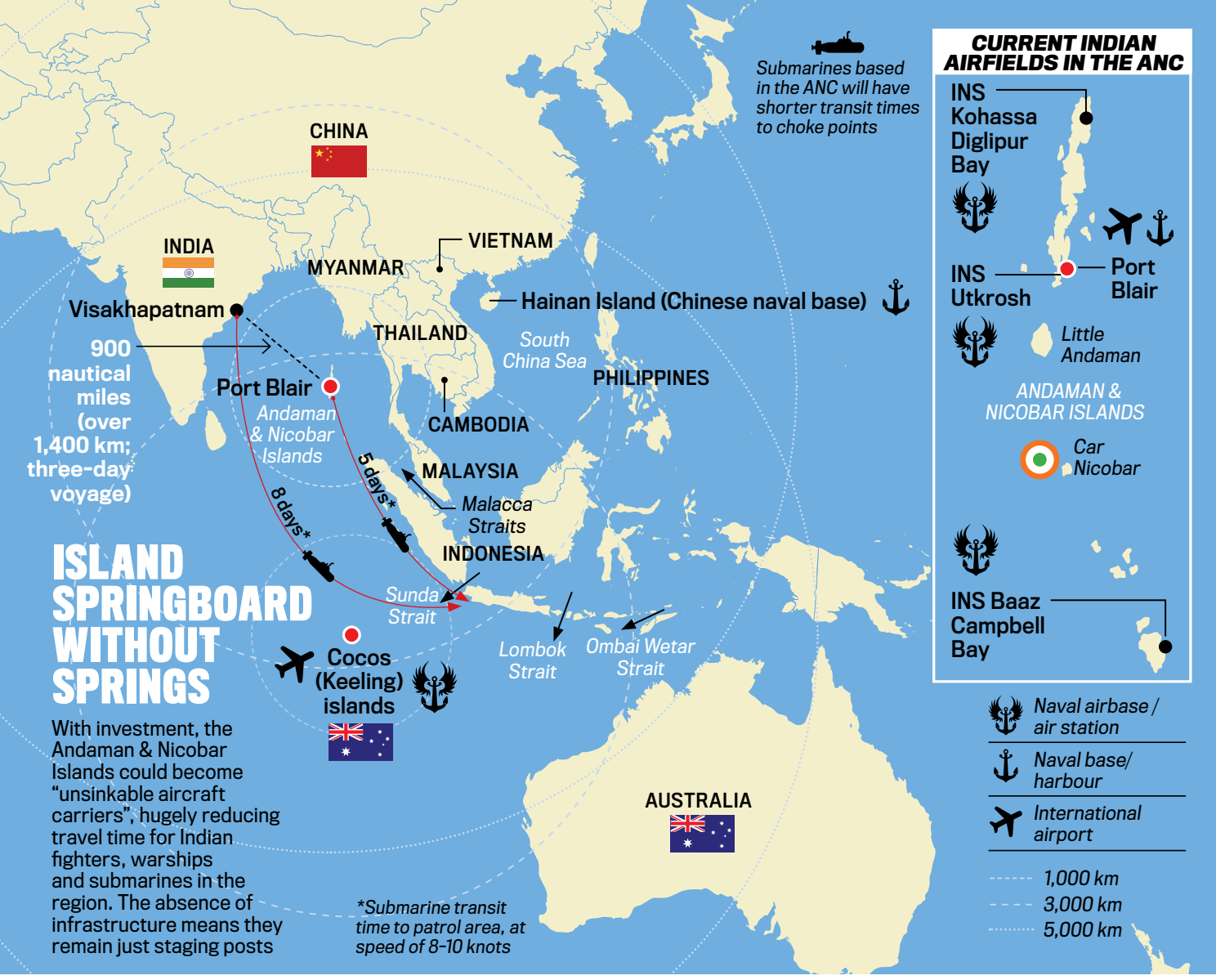


ISLAND SPRINGBOARD WITHOUT SPRINGS

With investment, the Andaman & Nicobar Islands could become "unsinkable aircraft carriers", hugely reducing travel time for Indian fighters, warships and submarines in the region. The absence of infrastructure means they remain just staging posts

potential of its island outposts to act on that vulnerability. The 572 islands in the A&N chain, of which only 32 are inhabited, constitute an area larger than the state of Sikkim. The group sits 1,400 km from the Indian mainland—closer, in fact, to Indonesia, Myanmar and Thailand than India itself.

China is using islands bristling with missiles, airfields and docks to dominate the South China Sea. The plan is for India to do the same with Andaman & Nicobar

In a report tabled in Parliament last December, the parliamentary standing committee on defence recommended that the islands be developed into 'aircraft carriers' of a kind. The islands, the committee said, were well suited to 'blocking and dominating ingress routes [into the Indian Ocean], provided runways there are made operational'. The archipelago is close to three critical chokepoints—the Ombai Wetar, Lombok and Sunda straits—through which the PLAN can enter the Indian Ocean. Aircraft based on the islands would have shorter flight times to these choke points than from the Indian mainland, and submarines based from here can reach in five days instead of eight, meaning they could spend more time patrolling. Currently, India is seeking basing rights for its P-8I anti-submarine warfare aircraft on Australia's Keeling Islands, also located near these points.

The A&N Islands currently have four airstrips, which host a handful of IAF helicopters, naval and coast guard surveillance helicopters and drones. A few patrol ships belonging to the navy and coast guard also operate in these waters. The IAF only occasionally bases fighter aircraft here—the islands are seen more as forward operating bases than full-strength military installations. The late Chief of Defence Staff General

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY